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Themes in Ancient and Medieval Philosophy

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On *Phantasia*'s Tactual Aspect

Aristotle's presentation of the soul classifies the souls of perishable living beings into a tripartite hierarchy, with each higher stratum building on capacities established at the level below (414b28-45). Those “creatures which have reason have all the rest” and so develop capacities not quite awakened in the creatures which have mere sense-perception. Within this framework, the faculty of imagination plays a double role. With the achievement of deliberative thought, the imagination becomes available for operation, whether for the purpose of engaging with abstract objects, creating or renovating mnemonic systems, or even just freely presenting images according to one's wish. At this level, Aristotle's metaphor of images as *pictures*, visually-rendered likenesses, seems fitting (427b18). Since the free employment of images suggests an increased awareness of their being mere resemblances of an original source, the imaged object only has a subdued power to affect, as if seen behind glass (OM 452b25, DA 427b20). The function of the imagination specific to this level of achievement has the tendency to stand for the function of the imagination in general. So much is the imagination as a whole associated with the exclusive rendering of visual phenomena that Aristotle explicitly underscores the link between *phantasia* and *phaos* (428b30). Yet, the rational animal not only employs the imagination at an affective remove, but somehow depends on it, in as much as the imagination originates and is closely knit with the clusters of faculties resulting from the achievement of sense-perception, specifically the *tactile*. The imagination is already operational in the ongoing sub-rational assessment of one's field of phenomena. Here, *phantasia* emerges not as *picture-making*, but as the affective

charging of the field of phenomena, incorporating an anticipation of future outcomes correspondent with the animal's innate mnemonic apparatus. As a preparatory study for distinguishing the dimensions of imagination operating in the soul of the human-being, I will attempt to clarify the function of the imagination in the soul of the animal. My approach will be to (1) establish the essential relation of animal *phantasia* to memory within Aristotle's account, (2) attempt to fill in a textual lacuna concerning the mechanisms by which perceptions are retained and systematized, and then (3) summarize the operation of the animal imagination.

1.

The qualitative division defining the animal soul occurs with the onset of *tactile perception*, the sense-faculty common to all living things which have sense-faculties (413b4). The ability to feel implies *pleasure-and-pain* and so also orienting to what is pleasant and recoiling from what is painful – *desire-and-aversion* (414b1). Aristotle often suggests the close involvement of *locomotion* and *imagination* within this dynamic (413b21, 432b16). Presumably, locomotion is the faculty by which the animal physically moves toward-or-away from the desirable-or-aversive phenomena, and imagination is some kind of bridge facilitating an impression of potentially realized states, so that they can be desired-or-avoided.

Aristotle stops short of saying locomotion and imagination arise necessarily with tactile perception. Not all that feel have locomotion, such as barnacles, nor do all that feel have imagination, such as grubs (428a10). If grubs, being animals, have pleasure-and-pain and so desire-and-aversion, but lack imagination, this would be to say that although they orient according to pleasure, they do not have a cognitive bridge providing a sense of the improved state. This distinction suggests that desire does not necessitate imagination, or that not every wanting for a state requires that that state not yet be somehow present. The object of a desire may therefore be said to be either within or beyond the

horizon of the immediate, and only in the case of the latter is imagination involved. Since the sense of an outcome of a preference must anticipate beyond the bounds of the present moment in order to qualify as imagination, and since the actual future state is yet unavailable, the desire-facilitating imagination must require the involvement of retained past experience for its function of suggesting future states.

While the task at hand is to elaborate the function of retained experience for the anticipating imagination, let us begin by reviewing the well-documented description of the remembering imagination taken simply. In *On Memory*, memory is identified as sense-perception modified by time (449b25). As memory always pertains to the past, it presupposes a sense of time (which belongs even to “many of the lower animals”) (450a17-18). This time sense is a construction deriving from immediate sense-perceptions (450a10). It facilitates the distinguishing between “here, now” and “passed away”. When a phenomenon is interpreted as past, its having-passed-away must be reconciled with its now-presenting. In order to account for this, the concept of the image must be evoked. The past-phenomenon suggests itself as both a first-order *presentation* in itself and a second-order *likeness* tied to an original presentation, i.e., a here-now *image of* a past-original. When the imagination is now-presenting a likeness of a past sense-perception, this is what is called *remembering* (451a15).

Despite memory's origin in the lower animals, the above angle of analysis proves disadvantageous for clarifying the way memory must function in the animal. Animals, unlike human-beings, are not capable of volitional acts of imagination. They can not self-initiate an act of remembering; this would be the exclusively human act of recollection, which functions over and above the remembering act shared by humans and animals (451b5). Animals remember in a way which is somehow non-volitional or autonomic, and so non-interruptive of their future-oriented pursuit of pleasures. By comparison, human-beings are able to shift out of a forward-flow into a slowed present, from which action and investigation can be volitionally initiated. Accordingly, an account of

remembering given from a paused cross-section of the immediate moment is liable to overrepresent the extent to which volition is occurring as part of the remembering act. Indeed, Aristotle's metaphor of the holding of the object of a picture for remembering aptly construes the ability of human-beings to handle and sort between images with varying degrees of affective remove, but obscures the character of the animal memory as singular and fixed, autonomic, and subsumed to the purpose of sensory anticipation. The account of remembering is so far missing an explanation of autonomic retention, organization, and retrieval, or of the way memory, as a faculty, operates.

2.

We find suggestions of such mechanisms in two places, neither of which explicitly delineate how retention functions in the animal soul simply. I will summarize both suggestions before returning to attempt an extrapolation. The first suggestion is found in *Posterior Analytics* II.19, where Aristotle writes: "...though sense-perception is innate in all animals, in some the sense-impression comes to persist, in others it does not. ... [A]nimals in which [this persistence] does come into being... can continue to retain the sense-impression in the soul" (99b35). This persistence and retention of sense-perceptions is identified as *memory* (100a4). Basic memory or retention, however, is augmented to the extent that given past impressions are capable of being meaningfully repeated: "when such persistence is frequently repeated a further distinction at once arises between those which out of the persistence of such sense-impressions develop a power of systematizing them and those which do not" (100a). Retention can be more or less *systematized*, and systematization somehow develops from the frequent repetition of sense-impressions. Presumably, the retracing of particular sense-impressions into the retentive bulk entrenches their impression, increasing their proportionate significance among the accrued mass of moments, as part of a continuous molding process. Aristotle identifies the systematizing act with the development of *experience*, the stabilizing of a universal in the soul, "the

one beside the many which is a single identity within them all” (100a5). Systematizing repetition, then, involves emphasizing a common or universal factor. The extent to which this systematization or experience-building occurs already at the level of the animal soul, however, is not here disambiguated.

The second suggestion of how memory operates is found in the second chapter of *On Memory* – the chapter reserved for discussion of recollection, the exclusively human ability to deliberately locate and summon a memory to mind. Recollection is possible in virtue of the property of causes to link together according to a sequence or structure, whether according to nature and necessity or engrained habit (451b10). The human-being hunts down a memory by imaging a past impression in the causal vicinity of the one he is after, and then following nearby paths through to his target. In addition to being able to self-initiate the retrieval of a memory, human-beings alone are capable of rehearsing various mnemonic techniques, such as imaging a place as a conceptual architecture for the purpose of reorganizing retained causal networks.¹ This mention of the way in which memories are organized and accessed, however, is set in the context of the discussion of the human activity of recollecting.

The suggestions must be refined before they can clarify the operation of memory in the animal. The disputed territory in the *Posterior Analytics* passage lies between the achievement of memory as basic retention – which belongs to some, perhaps most, animals – and the achievement of epistemic and technical understanding – distinctly human faculties here said to emerge from memory systematized into “stabilized universals” (or “experience”) (100a7). Aristotle does not here theorize on the ability or the extent to which animals are capable of meaningfully repeating sense-perceptions for the systematic organization of memories. Animals must have at least some capacity for this, however, since they evidently utilize past sense-impressions, and so must retain them by a process with some organizational or systematic efficiency. A clue to where the limit might lie is provided in the ambiguous link between *systematization* and *universalization*. It is unclear how an aggregation of ten imprints, repeated from a

¹ Aristotle refers to this method in particular at *On Memory* 452a12, *On Dreams* 458b20, and *Topics* 163b28.

single encounter (Aristotle's example), would have the same universalizing function as an aggregation of ten imprints, gathered together over a variety of encounters. The former would derive from a focused source, and could be manufactured at will, where the latter would derive from a diverse natural distribution. The link, then, implies two thresholds of systematic retention. The lower would be the ability to organize the retained sense-impressions according to nature, with each subsequent encounter in nature deepening and enriching the original impression, universalizing encountered phenomena but only according to an approximate natural distribution. The higher would be the ability to augment the lower level's method of processing with manual repetitions of sense-impressions, modifying memory beyond the proportions found in nature. Given that the higher kind of repetition would require the power to self-present past sense-impressions, a distinctly human capacity, we are left with the lower threshold to account for the systematization of animal memory.

The concept of a natural memory system can be elaborated with Chapter 2 of *On Memory*. The faculties of recollection and mnemonic projection are possible in virtue of the natural property of motions to fall together in causal links (451b12). These motions do not exist in divorced sequences but network together within a broad topography (452a15). The sense-impressions the animal is treading and retreading, then, will tend to follow the pattern of the pre-given, or natural, causal structure. While human-beings are able to forward various conceptual *topoi* as mnemonic modifiers, at the animal level only a single *topos* is assembled in memory, that which accords to the causal structure of its environment.

The animal's system for retaining past sense-impressions can now be compiled as follows. Whenever an animal with memory encounters a phenomenon, the impression it makes persists, or is retained, beyond the moment of perception. When an animal subsequently encounters similar phenomena, they will reinforce the remnants of the first impression. This repetition process has a universalizing function. If ten similar particulars are seen, their common feature will be impressed most

deeply. Over time, the universalizing function would amplify the differences between various phenomenal impressions, sculpting them into distinct sectors according to their peculiar causal dynamics. As an animal, for example, roams its spatial neighborhood, foraging and retracing efficient pathways, the impression gradually universalized in memory would be something like an overhead map. As the animal encounters other animals, the impression gradually universalized would be something like a taxonomy and social directory. In this way phenomena, existing in a given causal network, will impress the interconnected sectors of an altogether world upon the animal's memory, one peculiar to the animal's innate perceptive apparatus.

3.

Let us return to integrate this account of animal memory with cluster of faculties following from the achievement of tactile sense-perception: pleasure and desire, with imagination, and so memory, close behind. As the animal's desire for pleasures begins to anticipate beyond the immediate horizon, it must involve the imagination, which in turn depends for its predictions on applying memory's retained sense-impressions. Memory retains sense-impressions by repeatedly being subject to their causal links, and so gradually developing a sense of their networked significance. The animal's continued probings are motivated by its desire for pleasure, and so the mnemonic microcosm it shapes bears the felt history of consummated and frustrated desires.

This memory system enables the imagination to infuse the immediate, particular, field of perception with its more universalized significance – something like a probability map – suggesting where, on aggregate of prior experience, the phenomena's causal atmosphere indicates more or less pleasure or pain than would be immediately apparent. These integrated probabilistic supplementations operate as felt 'charges' to the immediate phenomena, marking off certain immediate paths as ultimately painful and highlighting more nuanced ones as ultimately pleasurable, and so channeling the animal's

desire toward pleasures determined not only with respect to the immediate moment but to an aggregate spanning a sensed succession of moments to come.

These images guide the animal's immediate desire, but can not completely contain it, which would make animals exemplars of temperance. The animal's memories are folded into its interpretation of the immediate sensory field, with the impressions most deeply engrained providing the strongest affective boundaries, practically cemented within its interpretation when aligned with the appropriate phenomena. Other retained impressions may be only partly applicable, or somehow contradictory, when confronting phenomena. The images produced by these impressions are especially liable to dissipate, for the following reason. Animals are not adept at quantitative measurement or abstract reasoning. While they must have some sense of time in order to have memory at all, they are not adept at weighing the interests of the immediate moment against those of the anticipated succession of moments (433b5). This confusion always biases toward the immediate moment, which looms largest in the animal's perspectival sense of time. Unless a *phantasm* derives from a deeply engrained causal history, the objective it suggests is liable to be shunted for an immediately available (large seeming) pleasure. In this way, the degree of anticipatory imagination involved in the animal's choice of object of desire is haphazard: “at one time this desire wins out and knocks away that one, and at another time that one wins out and knocks away this one” (434a10). Accordingly, the animal *phantasia* can be characterized as constituting pathways to pleasure valuable on relatively long-term aggregate, but with its affective charges able to be short-circuited by the appearance of a pressing immediately available pleasure. The animal is like a person with impaired depth-perception, who attempts to track an object in the distance, but whose attention continually slips to objects in the foreground without his even noticing.

The achievement of tactile sensation brings pleasure and desire, and later the anticipatory imagination powered by the memory. To be sure, the development of these latter faculties is

accompanied, or even dependent, on the arrival of other senses beyond the tactile. Tactile pleasure, however, always remains a fundamental aspect of the pleasure which motivates the animal's desire, and is embedded into the retained experience powering its imagination. The imagination, then, is misconstrued when represented only as a producer of visually-rendered likenesses, able to be considered at a remove. It must be remembered that the imagination also has a tactual aspect, which at an autonomic level electrifies the perceptive field. This aspect is active in maintaining tunnels leading to pleasures valuable on long-term aggregate. This significance of this conclusion can be provisionally indicated by its application to Aristotle's statement that "the soul never thinks without an image." This would be understood to involve a two-leveled function of the imagination: managed at the conscious level, as the application of pictures – largely visual, considered at a distance – through which the mind can focus on a likeness, and, managed at the sub-rational level, as the felt – largely tactual, immediately integrated – constitution of the perceptive field suggesting avenues of pursuit propitious for the acquisition of the kinds of pleasure appropriate to the thinking animal.